
Qualitative Research Methods: Overview

Advanced Topics: Methodology, Philosophy, and Research Design

1. Qualitative vs. Quantitative Paradigms

Quantitative: Counting, measuring, statistical analysis. Goal: objective, generalizable statements. Deductive.

Qualitative: Understanding meaning, reconstructing action orientations. Goal: deep understanding of individual cases. Inductive.

Not either-or: Depends on research question. Mixed methods combine both.

2. Key Principles of Qualitative Research

Openness: No rigid hypotheses before data collection. The field determines relevant categories.

Communication: The researcher is part of the field. Data arise in interaction.

Process character: Research is circular (not linear). Data collection and analysis alternate.

Reflexivity: The role of the researcher is reflected upon. Subjectivity is a tool, not a disturbance.

3. Quality Criteria in Qualitative Research

Classical criteria (reliability, validity, objectivity) do not fit one-to-one.

Procedural documentation: Every step is transparently documented.

Argumentative interpretation: Interpretations supported by material; alternatives discussed.

Communicative validation: Results presented to respondents for feedback.

Triangulation: Multiple methods, data sources, researchers, or theories.

Lincoln & Guba (1985): Credibility, Transferability, Dependability, Confirmability.

4. Typical Process of a Qualitative Study

(1) Develop research question (open, exploratory).

(2) Sampling: purposive or theoretical sampling.

(3) Data collection: interview, observation, documents.

(4) Processing: transcription (Dresing/Pehl rules), field notes.

(5) Analysis: coding, categorizing, typology building, theory development.

(6) Quality check: reflection, triangulation, communicative validation.